

Two routes to predicate ellipsis in Spanish: The clitic versus focus strategy

Abstract

This paper documents and analyzes a predicate ellipsis alternation found in contemporary Spanish, addressing some challenges it poses for current theories of ellipsis licensing with the Minimalist Program. Spanish predicate ellipsis occurs in two variants: (i) *lo-insertion*, where an overt proform (the neuter clitic *lo*) attaches to the auxiliary preceding the silent gap, and (ii) *lo-omission*, where predicate ellipsis is licensed under polarity focus (typically marked on the stranded auxiliary). Both variants arise from ellipsis of the main predicate—and its arguments—and are licensed by the same restricted class of auxiliaries. To account for their shared distribution, this paper argues against positing two distinct [E]-features. Instead, predicate ellipsis in both the *lo-insertion* and the *lo-omission* contexts are proposed to stem from a single [E]-feature. Concretely, the presence of a clitic (in *lo-insertion*) and its absence under polarity focus (in *lo-omission*) are analyzed as two alternative strategies to satisfy the semantic requirements of a single [E]-feature, without encoding these contexts for ellipsis directly in [E]’s syntax. This analysis is further extended to predicate ellipsis constructions in Germanic languages, which employ strategies for predicate anaphora akin to both *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission*, albeit with a different distribution.

Keywords: VP ellipsis, Ellipsis resolution, Focus, Clitics, VP anaphora

1. Introduction

This paper investigates two distinct—yet distributionally related—strategies for predicate anaphora in present-day Spanish, with the aim of identifying and subsequently addressing some of the challenges their analysis poses to current theories of ellipsis licensing within the Minimalist Program (Merchant 2001, Aelbrecht 2010). The first of these strategies, referred to in this paper as *lo-insertion*, is exemplified in (1), where the complement of a copula (1a-b) or an aspectual auxiliary (1c) is left unexpressed in the presence of an overt predicate proform—namely, the neuter pronominal clitic *lo* that surfaces attached to the higher auxiliary.

(1) Predicate Anaphora through *lo-insertion*

- a. María es una buena profesora y Cristina también lo es.
María is a good teacher and Cristina also CL.N is
‘María is a good teacher and Cristina is, too.’

- b. Sonia está embarazada y Natalia también lo está.
Sonia is pregnant and Natalia also CL.N is
'Sonia is pregnant and Natalia is, too.'
- c. Esta comunidad submarina está prosperando, o al menos
this community underwater is thriving or at least
lo estaba hace unos años.¹
CL.N was ago few years
'This underwater community is thriving, or at least it was a few years ago.'

While *lo-insertion* is one way to achieve predicate anaphor in Spanish, there is an alternative strategy, referred to in this paper as *lo-omission*, whereby the predicate clitic *lo* can be omitted under specific focus conditions. As first documented by Saab and Stigliano (2023; henceforth S&S23), the clitic *lo* may be omitted in the presence of polarity focus, i.e. verum focus. In such cases, exemplified in (2), the focal accent associated with verum focus falls on the auxiliary/copula immediately adjacent to the silent gap. Without this focus, *lo-omission* becomes ill-formed, and the clitic *lo* must appear, resulting in the *lo-insertion* pattern seen in (1) above.

(2) Predicate Anaphora through lo-omission

- a. Sonia no es feliz pero Bruno sí ES.
Sonia not is happy but Bruno yes is
'Sonia is not happy, but Bruno is indeed.'
- b. Sonia no está feliz pero Bruno sí ESTÁ.
Sonia not is happy but Bruno yes is
'Sonia is not happy but Bruno is indeed.'
- c. ?Sonia no está cantando pero Bruno sí ESTÀ.
Sonia not is singing but Bruno yes is
'Sonia is not singing and Bruno is, indeed'
(adapted from S&S23:29)

The *lo-insertion* vs. *lo-omission* split among Spanish predicate anaphora has not received much attention in previous literature, with S&S23 being a notable exception. These authors were, as far I can tell, the first to document this alternation with copular verbs in Spanish, proposing that it fits into Hankamer and Sag' (1976) "deep" vs. "surface" anaphora distinction in English. According to Hankamer and Sag, "surface" anaphora, such as ellipsis of the verb phrase (VPE) in English, arise from the non-pronunciation of a syntactic constituent when its content may be recoverable from a

¹ Example taken from <https://guiasyjuegos.com/isla-coral-guia-para-la-agricultura-oceanica/> (5 December 2024).

syntactically matching antecedent. In contrast, “deep” anaphora—with the English VP-proform *do it* as a prime exemplar— involves the use of a structureless proform inserted in the same position as the missing predicate. A reliable test distinguishing these two anaphoric processes is extraction, which is permissible from within the elided material in VPE (3a) but prohibited out of the structureless VP-proform *do it* in English (3b) (ellipsis is indicated by using strikethrough).

- (3) a. I don’t know which puppy you should adopt, but I don’t know which one_i you shouldn’t <adopt ~~t_i~~>.
 b. *I don’t know which puppy you should adopt, but I don’t know which one you shouldn’t do it. [adapted from Schuyler (2001)]

Building on Hankamer and Sag’ framework, S&S23 advocate for a “true” ellipsis analysis of *lo-omission*, while dismissing *lo-insertion* as a subspecies of ‘deep’ anaphora analogous to English *do it*. The key contrast that S&S23 provide in support of this analysis comes from A’-extraction in the context of Focus Fronting: this is allowed from within the elided material in *lo-omission* (4a) but prohibited out of *lo-insertion* (4b).

- (4) a. A’-extraction (*lo-omission*)
 [Context: Sonia is a physics professor]
 ¡No! DE LINGÜÍSTICA es <profesora ~~t_i~~>
 no of linguistics is professor
 ‘No! She’s a professor of LINGUISTICS.’
 b. A’-extraction (*lo-omission*)
 [Context: Sonia is a physics professor]
 *¡No! DE LINGÜÍSTICA lo es <profesora ~~t_i~~>
 no of linguistics CL.N is professor
 ‘No! She’s a professor of LINGUISTICS.’
 (adapted from S&S23: 9)

However, the ban on Focus Fronting observed by S&S23 for *lo-insertion* structures like (4b) appears to be the exception rather than the rule. This construction, in fact, patterns with English VPE, and not with ‘deep’ anaphora like *do it*, in allowing various types of extraction from within the missing constituent. This is illustrated by the passive sentence in (5a) for A-movement², and further exemplified by the example in (5b) for wh-movement.

² S&S23 report the example in (i) as ungrammatical in Rioplatense Spanish (Argentina); here, like in (5a) above, the VP complement of the passive auxiliary *ser* ‘be’ is left unpronounced, which according to these authors results in an ill-formed sequence. Given the structural parallelism between (i) and (5a), the contrasting grammatical status of these two passive sentences turns out to be particularly puzzling.

- (5) a. Los isleños no fueron interrogados; no lo fueron tampoco
 the islanders not were asked not CL.N were either
 veintitantos millones de argentinos₁ <interrogados-t₁>
 twenty-something million of Argentinians asked
 ‘The islanders were not asked, nor were the twenty-something
 Argentinians.’
 (Jorge L. Borges, *Clarín* 25/9/1982)
- b. Yo sé de qué chica está enamorado Juan, pero
 I know.1SG of which girl is in.love Juan but
 no sé de cuál_i lo estás tú <enamorado-t₁>
 not know.1SG of which CL.N are.2SG you
 ‘I know which girl Juan is in love with, but I don’t know which one you are.’

My main goal, in Section 2, is to show that Spanish *lo-insertion* exhibits the defining characteristics of ellipsis. To this end, I apply the standard diagnostic tests for ellipsis (Hankamer and Sag 1976, Merchant 2013) to the *lo-insertion* construction, concluding that S&S23’ ellipsis-based analysis of *lo-omission* should likewise be extended to *lo-insertion*.

Building on these results, I address the second goal of this paper: to provide a unified analysis of the *lo-insertion* vs. *lo-omission* split in Spanish. Concretely, I argue that *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* are two manifestations of a single ellipsis process, which targets the predicate complement to an auxiliary for deletion. Crucial evidence supporting this unified analysis—carefully examined in Section 3—lies in the symmetric distribution of these two constructions: specifically, both *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* are licensed by the same close-knit class of auxiliaries. This shared licensing ellipsis pattern not only supports the view that *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* form a predicate ellipsis alternation in Spanish, but also raises broader theoretical questions. Specifically, the analysis of this ellipsis alternation raises several issues for the theory

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- (i) A: ¿Fuiste reprimido por la policía? B: (*)Sí, lo fuí.
 were.2SG repressed by the police yes CL.N was.1SG
 ‘Were you repressed by the police?’ ‘Yes, I was.’

This puzzle disappears when we consider the possibility of idiolectal variation in Rioplatense Spanish, which may account for the contrasting grammatical judgments between (i) and (5a) in this dialect. While S&S23 deemed the sentence in (i) ungrammatical in Rioplatense Spanish, the one in (5a) was produced by a speaker of that same Spanish variety: namely, the Argentinian writer Jorge Luis Borges (*Clarín*, 25/9/1982). This suggests that, in some Spanish varieties, *lo-insertion* exhibits some intriguing idiolectal variation that merits to be carefully examined in further research. On the other hand, the speakers of the Castilian Spanish variety that I consulted—including myself—find (i) just as acceptable as (5a). For this reason, I will concentrate in this paper on the Castilian Spanish dialect, where judgments on *lo-insertion* appear to be more consistent across speakers.

of ellipsis licensing within the Minimalist Program, particularly regarding how the shared distribution, as well as the syntactic differences, in the *lo-insertion/lo-omission* alternation can be explained in a unified way.

In Minimalism, ellipsis arises from the action of a morphosyntactic feature—specifically, Merchant’s [E]-feature. This feature links the syntactic requirements of ellipsis with its silencing effect at the PF interface and its resolution in the semantic component. While the silencing and semantic properties of [E] remain constant, the syntactic environments where [E] is licit to occur vary crosslinguistically and among distinct constructions within a single language. To account for this variation, Merchant (2001) associates different ellipsis patterns with a distinctive [E]-feature. Each [E], then, is endowed itself with a unique combination of uninterpretable features, which vary in accordance with the syntactic environment where each ellipsis pattern occurs (see Aelbrecht 2010 for some notable extensions to the syntax of [E]).

By assigning a unique [E] to each licensing environment, Merchant’s theory can therefore describe multiple licensing ellipsis patterns. However, this approach struggles to provide a unified analysis for ellipsis alternations like *the lo-insertion vs. lo-omission* split in Spanish. Concretely, Merchant’s theory faces the following challenge. If, on the one hand, *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* are assigned a different [E]-feature each—one encoding the polarity focus requirement and the other, the co-presence of the clitic *lo*—, the generalization about the shared class of verbal licensors in this alternation would be left unexplained. Conversely, assigning the same [E] feature to both constructions would account for their symmetry in terms of ellipsis licensors but fails to address the distinct role played by the neuter clitic *lo* and verum focus in each construction.

To address this challenge, I propose analyzing the presence of the clitic *lo* (in *lo-insertion*) and its absence under polarity focus (in *lo-omission*) as two alternative strategies for satisfying the Focus condition (Merchant 2001) imposed by a single [E]-feature.

(6) **Focus Condition**

(Merchant 2001:26)

A constituent α can be elided if α is e-GIVEN.

Roughly speaking, the e-GIVEN notion amounts to a mutual entailment relation between the Elided Constituent (EC) and a salient Antecedent Constituent (AC), modulo focus alternatives. Following Merchant (2001), I assume that [E] encodes the Focus condition as a presupposition (i.e., that the EC is e-GIVEN), but implement this assumption by formalizing the e-GIVEN notion as a binary predicate, as defined in (7).

$$(7) \quad \llbracket E \rrbracket = \lambda p_1 \lambda p_2: e - \text{GIVEN}(p_1, p_2).p_1$$

According to its semantic entry in (7), $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ must take two distinct arguments to be semantically well-formed: (i) a pronominal variable anaphorically linked to the AC, and (ii) the EC itself. Thus, an important consequence of this analysis is that the mapping between the e-GIVEN relation (i.e., EC and AC entail each other) and the LF-structures where this relation holds is more direct than previously assumed. Building on this mapping, it is possible to account for why predicate ellipsis yields the *lo-insertion* vs. *lo-omission* split in Spanish from a single $[E]$ -feature.

In *lo-insertion*, the clitic *lo* is anaphoric to the AC and, upon merging with the E-bearing head, it serves as one of the arguments of the e-GIVEN relation, with the other being the EC itself.

In *lo-omission*, by contrast, the E-bearing head does not adjoin to a clitic. Instead, it moves to adjoin to a F(ocus)-marking category (typically, Σ_F). In this configuration, the AC argument of $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ is supplied by the silent contextual variable associated with the squiggle operator ‘ $\sim$ ’ (Rooth 1992), which ensures the proper interpretation of focus. As a result, the silent contextual variable associated with focus plays a dual role: it acts both as the background of focus and as the AC of argument of $\llbracket E \rrbracket$. A welcome consequence of this analysis is that the *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* contexts can be independently derived from the semantics of a single $[E]$ -feature, and therefore they need not to be encoded as two distinct $[E]$ -features.

The rest of this paper is structured as follows. In Section 2 novel evidence is presented against analyzing *lo-insertion* as ‘deep’ anaphora, showing instead that it passes standard tests for ellipsis. Section 3 carefully examines the distributional similarities of *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission*, focusing on how these two constructions are consistently licensed by the same set of verbal licensors. Section 4 explores the role that the semantics of $[E]$ plays in licensing predicate ellipsis in Spanish. This section also introduces the formal semantic mechanisms involved in the recoverability of the ellipsis site, including the interaction of the e-GIVENness notion, focus marking, and silent (and overt) variables. Finally, Section 5 concludes the paper.

2. Spanish *lo-insertion* is ellipsis

Spanish *lo-insertion* exhibits all the hallmarks of “surface” anaphora, as it successfully passes the standard diagnostic tests for ellipsis (Hankamer and Sag 1976, 1984; Merchant 2013 and related work). Although *lo-insertion* superficially resembles “deep” anaphora like the English proform *do it*—leaving a neuter pronoun (*lo* in Spanish and

it in English) as an anaphoric predicate—, it behaves like *true* ellipsis rather than “deep” anaphora.

2.1 Missing antecedents

lo-insertion can provide a new referent for a pronoun located in a subsequent sentence, thereby passing the so-called Missing Antecedent test (Grinder and Postal 1971, Hankamer and Sag 1976).

- (8) a. *Pedro nunca ha estado casado con una mujer_i, y todavía la_i ama.
 Pedro never has been married with a woman and still CL.ACC loves
 ‘Pedro has never been married to a woman and still loves her.’
- b. Pedro nunca ha estado casado con una mujer, pero
 Pedro never has been married with a woman, but
 yo sí lo estuve, y todavía la amo.
 I yes CL.N was.1SG and still CL.ACC loves
 ‘Pedro has never been married to a woman, but I was, and I still love her.’

(8a) serves as the baseline example, illustrating that the accusative clitic *la* ‘her’ cannot co-refer an indefinite DP (*una mujer* ‘a woman’) when the latter is under the scope of negation. The example featuring *lo-insertion* is provided in (8b); here, like in (8a), the indefinite *una mujer* is overtly negated in the first sentence. However, the clitic *la* in (8b), unlike in (8a), is able to retrieve its antecedent within the ellipsis site. This is possible only if the ellipsis site contains a silent occurrence of *una mujer*, enabling *la* to co-refer with it, as schematically represented in (9) for (8b).

- (9) Pedro nunca ha estado casado con una mujer, pero
 Pedro never has been married with a woman, but
 yo sí lo estuve <casado con una mujer_i>, y todavía la_i amo.
 I yes CL.N was.1SG and still CL.ACC loves
 ‘Pedro has never been married to a woman, but I was, and I still love her.’

As for the Missing Antecedent test, *lo-insertion* thus patterns with VPE in English, as illustrated in (10a), and not with “deep” anaphora like English *do it*, which fails to support a missing antecedent reading, as shown in (10b).

- (10) a. I’ve never ridden a camel, but Ivan has <ridden a camel₁>, and he says it₁ stank horribly.
 b. *Jack didn’t cut Berry with a knife—but Bill did it, and it₁ was rusty.
 [it₁= the knife Bill cut Berry with]
 (Hankamer and Sag 1976: (23b), (30))

2.2 Pragmatic versus linguistic antecedents

lo-insertion requires a linguistic antecedent to be well-formed, being ungrammatical when controlled by an exophoric antecedent. This behavior contrasts with the predicate proform *así* ‘so’, whose reference may be determined by the extralinguistic context.

(11) [Context: Looking at an extraordinary fat man in the street]

A: *¿Yo lo soy?

I CL.N am

(lit.) ‘Am I?’

A’. ¿Yo soy así?

I am so

‘Am I like that?’

Although the property of *being (extraordinary) fat* is rendered salient by the non-linguistic context in (11A), *lo-insertion* is ungrammatical in this context due to the absence of a linguistic antecedent. This stands in sharp contrast with the behavior of the proform *así* in (11A’), where it functions as a predicate anaphor even in the absence of a linguistic antecedent.

This need for a linguistic antecedent makes *lo-insertion* similar to English VPE, and distinguishes it from the VP proform *do it*, which can be controlled by a pragmatic antecedent (Hankamer and Sag 1976; however, see Merchant 2004 for an analysis of some deictic uses of VPE in English).

(12) [Context: Watching a pantomimed threat to break something]

A: He won’t do it.

B: ??He won’t.

(Bentzen, Merchant and Svenonius 2013)

2.2 A-extraction: passives and tough-Movement

For some speakers (see fn. 2), *lo-insertion* is legitimate with the passive auxiliary *ser* ‘be’, as exemplified in (5a) from section 1, repeated here as (13a), and further illustrated in (13b).

(13) a. Los isleños no fueron interrogados; no lo fueron tampoco

the islanders not were asked not CL.N were either

veintitantos millones de argentinos.

twenty-something million of Argentinians

‘The islanders were not asked, nor were the twenty-something million

Argentiniens.’ (Jorge L. Borges, *Clarín* 25/9/1982)

- b. Todos eran inocentes porque tenían derecho a ser juzgados
all were.3PL innocent because had.3PL right to be tried
reglamentariamente y no lo fueron.³
legally and not CL.N were.3PL
"All were innocent because they had the right to be tried in accordance with
the law, but they were not (tried in accordance with the law)."

Given the well-established assumption that passives arise from A-movement, wherein the internal argument of a transitive verb checks (or values) its Case feature by moving to the specifier of a higher Case-checking head (Chomsky 1981; Burzio 1986; Baker, Johnson and Roberts 1989, and much subsequent work), it follows that *lo-insertion* permits A-extraction from within the missing VP.

Additional evidence supporting the ellipsis analysis of *lo-insertion* in Spanish comes from *tough*-movement. In this construction, an object DP (henceforth, the *tough*-argument) moves from its thematic position inside the embedded infinitive of an adjective (typically, *fácil* 'easy' and *difícil* 'tough') to a Case-checking position in the matrix clause, as roughly represented in (14).

- (14) Estos libros_i son [fáciles [de leer t_i]]
these books are.3PL easy.PL to read
'These books are easy to read.'

Adjectives of the *tough*-class, such as *fácil* 'easy' and *difícil* 'tough', are well-known for assigning a thematic role to the embedded infinitive, but not to the *tough*-argument. Evidence for this lack of thematic assignment comes from the alternation between the *tough*-movement structure (14) above and its impersonal counterpart in (15).

- (15) Es fácil [leer estos libros] (cf. *son fáciles leer estos libros)
is.3SG easy.SG read these books is.3PL easy.PL read these books
'It is easy to read these books.'

Although (14) and (15) do not vary in meaning, their underlying syntax is completely different. In the impersonal structure in (15), the *tough*-argument remains within the infinitive, falling to agree with either the inflected copula or the adjective. In contrast, in the *tough*-movement structure in (14), the *tough*-argument moves out the infinitive, agreeing in number and person with the copular verb and in number with the adjective.

³ Taken from <https://ctxt.es/es/20210101/Firmas/34592/memoria-jorge-marco-memorial-madrid-almeida-largo-caballero-fernando-holgado.htm> (5 December 2024).

Tough-movement in Spanish, as well as in closely related Romance languages such as French, Italian and Portuguese, patterns with passives in involving a local, A-movement dependency between a DP in subject position and a silent gap in the object position of a transitive verb (see Montalbetti and Saito 1983 for Spanish; Rizzi 1982 and Cinque and Benincà 2018 for Italian; Authier and Reed 2009 for French; and Giurgea and Soare 2010 for Romanian). The local nature of Spanish *tough*-movement is exemplified by the ill-formedness of (16a), where the presence of a second infinitive (in this case, *lamentar* ‘regret’) creates a barrier for A-movement. In such cases, the *tough*-argument must stay in its argument position within the infinitival clause, as illustrated by the well-formedness of its impersonal counterpart in (16b).⁴

- (16) a. *Estos libros son fáciles de lamentar haber leído.
 these books are.3PL easy.PL to regret have read
 ‘These books are easy to regret having read.’
 b. Es fácil lamentar haber leído esos libros.
 is.3SG easy.3SG regret have read these books
 ‘It’s easy to regret having read these books.’

Although the A-movement analysis of Spanish *tough*-movement would merit further investigation (see fn. 4 and the references given below), what interests us here is that *tough*-movement is permissible under *lo-insertion*, as exemplified below.

- (17) Juan es fácil de agradar, pero tú no lo eres.
 Juan is.3SG easy.SG to please but you not CL.N are.2SG
 ‘Juan is easy to please, but you are not (easy to please).’

In sharp contrast to *lo-insertion*, the proform *así* ‘so’, which behaves as ‘deep’ anaphora by allowing pragmatic control— as shown in (11A’) above—, cannot take as its antecedent an adjective selecting a *tough*-movement infinitive:

- (18) a. *Juan es fácil de agradar, pero tú no eres así.
 Juan is.3SG easy.SG to please but you not are.2SG so
 ‘Juan is easy to please, but you are not as easy.’

⁴ As is well-known, *tough*-movement in English, unlike in Spanish, involves an unbounded dependency between the *tough*-argument and the gap inside the infinitival clause. This is evident from the fact that the English counterpart of (17) is fully grammatical. It is commonly accepted that *tough*-movement in English involves the displacement of a null operator (OP) to an A'-position located in the left periphery of the infinitival clause. The *tough*-argument, in turn, is directly merged with the *tough*-predicate in the matrix clause, and forms a binding chain with the lower OP in infinitival clause, as schematically represented in (i) (see Chomsky 1981, Hicks 2009, Brillman 2017, among many others).

(i) These books₁ are easy [OP_i [to convince my students to read t_i]]

- b. *?Marina es fácil de agradar y así soy yo también.
 Marina is.3SG easy.SG to please and so am I too
 ‘Marina is easy to please, and so am I.’

The ill-formedness of the examples in (18) stems from the lack of internal structure of the proform *así*, rendering it incapable of hosting the A-trace/copy of the *tough*-argument. Crucially, this prohibition on *tough*-movement does not apply to *lo-insertion* structures like (17), providing strong evidence against treating it as a ‘deep’ anaphor devoid of inner structure.

2.2 A'-extraction

This subsection has two distinct goals. The first is to show that various types of A'-movement operations are able to target the ellipsis site in *lo-insertion*, thereby extending the findings on A-extraction from previous section to A'-extraction. The second is to critically evaluate S&S23's main argument against analyzing *lo-insertion* as a *bona fide* ellipsis phenomenon—concretely, their claim that Focus Fronting is prohibited in the context of *lo-insertion*. Upon closer examination, I argue that this claim is not empirically accurate. On the contrary, Focus Fronting is permissible in the context of *lo-insertion* under specific conditions, which brings additional evidence in favor of treating *lo-insertion* as ellipsis.

Firstly, a *wh*-object can undergo A'-movement from within its argument position within the ellipsis site to its surface position in the left periphery of the clause (typically, *Spec,CP*). In addition to the example from section 1, repeated here as (19a), the examples in (19b-c) serve to further illustrate *wh*-extraction from within the missing material.

- (19) a. Yo sé de qué chica está enamorado Juan, pero
 I know.1SG of which girl is in.love Juan but
 no sé de cuál_i lo estás tú <enamorado-t₁>
 not know.1SG of which CL.N are.2SG you
 ‘I know which girl Juan is in love with, but I don’t know which one you are.’
 b. Sospecho que Juan es pariente del novio, pero no sé
 suspect.1SG that Juan is relative of.the groom, but not know.1SG
 de quién₁ lo es esa mujer <pariente-t₁>
 of who CL.N is that woman relative
 ‘I suspect Juan is a relative of the groom, but I don’t know who that woman is [a relative of].’

- c. Tu amigo Pedro está enfadado conmigo. ¿Adivinas con quién₁
 your friend Pedro is angry with me guess with who
 lo estoy yo <enfadado-t₁>?
 CL.N am I
 ‘Your friend Pedro is angry with me. Guess who I am [angry with]?’

Secondly, Left Dislocation (LD), which places a topic constituent into a position reserved for contrastive topics within the clause’s left periphery (Rizzi 1997, Zubizarreta 1998, López 2009 and references cite therein), can occur in the context of *lo-insertion*. This is illustrated in (20); here, the topic PP *con Pedro* ‘with Pedro’ in the second conjunct starts in its argument position within the missing predicate and undergoes LD to a position associated with contrastive topics within the clause’s left periphery.

- (20) Con Juan está casada María, pero con Pedro lo está Sonia <casada-t₁>
 with Juan is married Mary but with Pedro CL.N is Sonia married
 (lit.) ‘To Juan, María is married, but to Pedro Sonia is.’

It is worth noting that the LD-ed topic in the second clause in (19), *con Pedro*, cannot be dismissed as a base-generated topic—i.e. as a Hanging Topic (HT). HTs, unlike LD-ed topics, are well-known (i) for being optionally introduced by the expression *en cuanto a* ‘as for’ and (ii) for being separated by a strong prosodic break from a gap-less clause (Cinque 1990, Casielles-Suárez 2004). This is illustrated in (21), where the HT *en cuanto a Pedro* is directly inserted in its surface position and fails to be associated with a silent gap in its host clause.

- (21) *Hanging Topic*
 En cuanto a Pedro_i, está casada Sonia {con él_i /con ese cretino_i / *Ø_i}
 as for to Pedro is married Sonia with him/with that bastard
 ‘As for Pedro, Sonia is married to {him/that bastard}’

Crucially, the *lo-insertion* example in (20) above becomes ill-formed if the LD-ed topic is replaced by a *true* HT, as shown in (22). This substitution test indicates that the syntactic structure underlying the *lo-insertion* sentence in (20) does not feature a base-generated HT, but a LD-ed topic.

- (22) *Con Juan está casada María, pero en cuanto a Pedro lo está Sonia.
 with Juan is married María but as for to Pedro CL.N is Sonia
 (lit.) ‘To Juan, María is married, but as for Pedro Sonia is.’

Thirdly, *lo-insertion* may surface in the standard of an equality comparative, which in Spanish is introduced by the standard marker *como* ‘as’:

- (23) a. Papuchi estuvo casado con tantas mujeres como lo estuvo su hijo.
 Papuchi was married with many women as it.CL was his son
 ‘Papuchi was married to as many women as his son was.’
 b. El presidente de Argentina es amigo de tantos mafiosos
 the president of Argentina is friend of many mobsters
 como lo es su homólogo español.
 as it.CL is his counterpart Spanish
 ‘The Argentinian primer minister is friends with as many mobsters as
 his Spanish counterpart is.’
 c. Ha sido cariñosa con tantos concursantes como lo fui yo.
 has been affectionate with many contestants as CL.N was I
 ‘She has been affectionate with as many contestants as I was.’

According to the established literature on the syntax and semantics of comparative constructions (Bresnan 1971, Chomsky 1977, Kennedy 2002 and related work), comparatives involve a silent operator that quantifies over quantities/degrees. This comparative operator undergoes A'-movement to a higher scope position within the standard clause, and adheres to standard island constraints. This is exemplified in (24) in Spanish for the Complex NP Constraint.

- (24) *Juan compró tantos libros como el hombre que {compró/vendió}.
 Juan bought as books as the man that bought/sold
 *‘Juan bought as many books as the man that bought/sold.’

Building on this analysis, it is reasonable to conclude that in the *lo-insertion* structures in (23), the ellipsis site hosts the trace/copy of a null comparative operator, as sketched in (25) for the LF structure underlying (23a).⁵

⁵ For reasons that are yet poorly understood, it is not possible to test whether *lo-insertion* allows A'-extraction in inequalities comparatives in Spanish. These constructions introduce the standard clause with the complementizer *que* and, unlike equality comparatives like (23), must adhere to a constraint whereby the overt material in the standard clause must have a contrastive correlate in the main clause to be well-formed (Reglero 2007).

- (i) Juan leyó más libros que {*leyó} Pedro {*leyó}.
 Juan read more books than read Pedro read
 ‘Juan read more book than Pedro read.’

In (i), *Pedro* in the standard clause contrasts with the subject DP *Juan* in the main clause. However, the verb in both clauses is the same, *leyó*, and its repetition renders the sentence ungrammatical. For the

- (25) ...con tantas mujeres [como [OP₁ [lo estuvo su hijo <casado-t₁>]]
 with many women as CL.N was his son married

Before concluding this section, I address S&S23's claim that *lo-insertion* is best analyzed as a 'deep' anaphor, primarily due to its apparent inability to allow A'-extraction out of the ellipsis site. This argument is grounded on the observation that Focus Fronting (FF)—a movement operation displacing a focal constituent from its canonical argument position to the clause-initial position—fails to apply in the context of *lo-insertion*, as illustrated below (examples adapted from S&S23).

(26) Focus Fronting

- A: Sonia es fanática de Boca.
 Sonia is fan of Boca
 'Sonia is fan of Boca'
 B: *_iNo! DE ATLANTA lo es.
 no of Atlanta CL.N is
 'No! Of Atlanta she is (a fan)'

In light of the full range of A'-extraction paradigms discussed in this section, the ill-formedness of (26B) should not be regarded as compelling evidence against an ellipsis-based analysis of *lo-insertion*. However, given that various types of A'-extraction are permitted from within the elided material, the specific prohibition on FF presents a particularly intriguing puzzle.⁶ Why does FF behave differently from other A'-movement operations in this context?

sentence to be well-formed, the verb in the standard clause must be elided (see Vela-Plo 2020 for a coordination-based approach to the syntax of inequality comparatives that may explain this and related restrictions). Given this constraint, it comes as no surprise that *lo-insertion* becomes ungrammatical in the context of inequality comparatives, as shown in (ii.a). Here, the copula in the standard clause, *es*, lacks a contrastive correlate in the main clause and must be elided. Importantly, the same restriction applies to the non-elliptical source of the *lo-insertion* sentence in (ii.b), confirming that the ungrammaticality of (ia) is unrelated to *lo-insertion* itself.

- (i) a. Juan es amigo de más políticos que Juan (*lo es).
 (lit.) 'Juan is a friend of more politicians that Juan is'.
 b. Juan es amigo de más políticos que Juan (*es amigo).
 (lit.) 'Juan is a friend of more politicians that Juan is a friend of.'

⁶ One might speculate that a "deep'-anaphor approach to *lo-insertion* is correct for Rioplatense Spanish, but incorrect for Castilian Spanish. However, the fact that (26B) is equally ungrammatical in these two Spanish varieties strongly undermines this hypothesis. It is worth noticing, however, that the grammatical status of FF varies across different Spanish dialects: specifically, it has been reported that, in Mexican Spanish, the focus constituent cannot undergo FF and must occur *in-situ* irrespective of whether it is contrastive or not (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2002). For these speakers, we thus expect (4a) and (26B) to be equally ungrammatical (but see fn. 7).

To address this question, some important facts regarding the interaction of FF with the contrastive negative particle *no* in Spanish (Brunetti 2004, López 2009) must be taken into consideration.

To begin, when the clause is preceded by the contrastive negative particle *no*, as in (26B) above, FF results in an ill-formed sequence regardless of whether *lo-insertion* applies. This is evident not only in (26B) but also in non-elliptical sentences like (27a). In this example, the main predicate does not undergo *lo-insertion*, yet FF still leads to ungrammaticality. By contrast, when FF does not apply to the non-elliptical sentence in (27a), the resulting sentence in (27b) becomes well-formed. Similarly, *lo-insertion* also becomes well-formed in the absence of FF, as exemplified in (27c). In this pseudo-gapping structure, the focus constituent CON JACINTO is neither targeted for deletion nor for FF.

- (27) [Context: Sonia is married to Pedro.]
- a: */??; NO! CON JACINTO₁ está casada t₁. [cf. (26B)]
 no with Jacinto is married
 ‘??No! TO JACINTO she is married.’
- b. ¡NO! Está casada CON JACINTO.
 ‘No! She is married TO JACINTO’
- c. ¡NO! lo está CON JACINTO.
 ‘No! She is TO JACINTO’

What this paradigm shows is that the incompatibility between FF and *lo-insertion* seen in (26B) above is not a quirk of *lo-insertion*. For one thing, this very same prohibition on FF also apply to the non-elliptical source of *lo-insertion* (see Brunetti 2004 for an analysis of this constraint in English and Italian).

More importantly, when the sentence is not preceded by the contrastive negative particle *no*, FF is permissible in non-elliptical structures, as shown in (28a). Crucially, the same holds true for *lo-insertion*, as shown in (28b)

- (28) [Context: Sonia is married to Pedro.]
- a. CON JACINTO está casada t₁ (, no con Pedro)
 with Jacinto is married not with Pedro
 ‘TO JACINTO she is married (, not with Pedro)’
- b. CON JACINTO lo está ~~casada~~ t₁ (, no con Pedro)
 with Jacinto CL.N is married not with Pedro
 ‘TO JACINTO she is (, not with Pedro)’

López (2009) argues that in the presence of the contrastive negative particle *no*, the focus constituent is not inherently contrastive. This is so because “negation does the contrast work” and therefore “the focused constituent may just be plain information focus” [López 2009: 56]. It is well-known that plain information (non-contrastive) foci fail to undergo A'-movement to the clause-initial position in most Spanish dialects, as illustrated by the ungrammaticality of FF in the answer to (29A):

- (29) A: ¿Con quién está casada María?
 ¡To whom is Mary married?'
 B: {*CON JACINTO} está casada {CON JACINTO}.
 with Jacinto is married with Jacinto

If López's (2009) analysis is on the right track, it follows that *lo-insertion* permits FF under the same conditions that license FF in non-elliptical contexts—specifically, when the focus constituent is [+contrastive]⁷, as in (28b), but not when it is [-contrastive], exemplified in (26B).

⁷ From this perspective, the grammaticality of the *lo-omission* sentence in (4a), repeated here as (i), is particularly puzzling. In this example, the contrastive particle *no* precedes a sentence where the focus constituent undergoes fronting, which would typically result in an ill-formed sequence. Contrary to expectations, the sentence is grammatical:

- (i) [Context: Sonia is a physics professor]
 ¡No! DE LINGÜÍSTICA es <profesora t₁>
 no of linguistics is professor
 'No! She's a professor of LINGUISTICS.'

Although a full account of this construction falls outside the scope of this paper, I can offer a tentative explanation for its exceptional grammatical status. This is based on the observation that, in *lo-omission* structures, the copula/auxiliary tends to appear in the rightmost clausal position. In Spanish this position is where the default rules of prosody assign the Nuclear Accent (NA) (Zubizarreta 1998). Let us assume that the copula/auxiliary in the *lo-omission* construction is associated with a [-contrastive] focus feature. Thus, since the copula/auxiliary is F-marked, it must receive the NA, which is typically assigned to the constituent in the rightmost clausal position. If an analysis along these lines proves correct, the sentence in (i) might be derived from the pseudogapping structure in (iia). Here, the copula cannot be assigned the NA because the focus constituent stays in the rightmost clausal position. To resolve this, an operation similar to Zubizarreta's (1998) *prosodic movement* (p-movement) places the PP *de lingüística* to the left of the copula, enabling the copula to receive the NA.

- (ii) a. ¡No! es de lingüística. → p-movement of “de lingüística”
 b. ¡No! de lingüística₁ ES t₁

Evidence supporting this analysis comes from the observation that *lo-omission* cannot enter *pseudogapping* structures like (iii). Here, p-movement fails to apply, leaving the focus constituent in the rightmost position. As a result, the copula is unable to receive the NA, which explains why (iii) turns out to be ungrammatical.

- (iii) [same context as (i)]
 *¡No! es DE LINGÜÍSTICA.

Summarizing so far, the ellipsis site accompanying the clitic *lo* in the *lo-insertion* construction can host the trace/copy of various kinds of movement operations, including:

- (i) A-movement in passive and *tough*-movement contexts,
- (ii) *wh*-movement,
- (iii) movement of a left dislocated topic,
- (iv) movement of a silent comparative operator, and
- (v) A'-movement of a [+contrastive] focus constituent.

Having established that *lo-insertion* arises from the ellipsis of the main clausal predicate (i.e. predicate ellipsis), the next section delves into several important issues regarding the syntactic distribution of this predicate ellipsis construction and its connection with *lo-omission*.

3. Same licensing heads, same ellipsis

This section investigates the syntactic distribution of predicate ellipsis in both *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* contexts, concentrating on which specific auxiliaries can directly precede the ellipsis site in each case. The aim is to identify whether the set of auxiliaries permitting their complement to be silent is consistent across the two contexts or varies between them. Examining this issue is essential for determining whether *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* arise from two distinct ellipsis processes—each associated with a different set of licensors—or whether they represent two manifestations of the same underlying process, with the same type of ellipsis operating under varying conditions. As a result of this investigation, it will be possible to establish a novel generalization regarding the syntactic distribution underlying the *lo-insertion* vs. *lo-omission* split in Spanish:

- (30) *lo-insertion* ↔ *lo-omission*
 The auxiliaries that license predicate ellipsis in the *lo-omission* context are precisely those that license it in the *lo-insertion* context, and vice versa.

To explain the symmetrical distribution of this ellipsis alternation, I propose extending S&S23' [E]-feature analysis of *lo-omission* to *lo-insertion*. Achieving this requires removing any reference to polarity focus or the neuter clitic *lo* from the [E]-feature responsible for licensing predicate ellipsis. This adjustment allows for the derivation of the two distinct contexts in which predicate ellipsis is licensed—under polarity focus

and by the co-presence of the neuter clitic *lo*—from the semantics of a single [E]-feature, a topic that will be explored further in Section 4.

3.1. Ellipsis of the small clause in copular sentences

In their examination of Small Clause Ellipsis (SCE) within the domain of copular verbs, S&S23 provide a key insight: SCE is uniformly licensed by the same class of verbal licensors across both *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* contexts. These licensors—identified by S&S23 as *true copulative verbs*—include: the individual-level copula *ser*, the stage-level copula *estar*, and the raising verb *parecer* ‘seem’, as illustrated in (31) for the *lo-insertion* context.

(31) *lo-insertion*

- a. María es una buena profesora y Cristina también lo es.
Sonia is a good teacher and Bruno also CL.N is
‘Sonia is happy and Bruno is, too.’
- b. Sonia está embarazada y Natalia también lo está.
Sonia is pregnant and Natalia also CL.N is
‘Sonia is pregnant and Natalia is, too.’
- c. Sonia no está embarazada pero lo parece.
Sonia not is pregnat but CL.N seems
‘Sonia is not pregnant, but she looks like (pregnant)’

The corresponding *lo-omission* paradigm in (32) further demonstrates that *true copular verbs* also license SCE in this context.

- (32)
- | | | |
|-----------------------|-----------------|------------|
| a. A: ¿Eres feliz? | B: Sí, SOY. | |
| ‘Are you happy?’ | ‘Yes, I am.’ | |
| b. A: ¿Estás feliz? | B: Sí, ESTOY. | |
| ‘Are you happy?’ | ‘Yes, I am.’ | |
| c. A: ¿Parezco feliz? | B: Sí, PARECES. | |
| ‘Do I seem happy?’ | ‘Yes, you do.’ | [S&S23: 8] |

S&S23 further show that pseudo-copulative verbs like *considerar* ‘consider’ or *ponerse* ‘become’ cannot leave their small clause complement unexpressed, neither in the *lo-insertion* nor in the *lo-omission* context, as shown in (33) and (34), respectively.

- (33)
- | | |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| A: ¿Consideras a Sonia inteligente? | B: *Sí, lo considero. |
| consider.2SG DOM Sonia intelligent | yes CL.N consider.1SG |
| ‘Do you consider Sonia intelligent?’ | ‘Yes, I do’ (lit) ‘I consider it.’ |

- (34) A: ¿Consideras a Sonia inteligente? B: *Sí, CONSIDERO.
 consider.2SG DOM Sonia intelligent yes consider.1SG
 'Do you consider Sonia intelligent? 'Yes, I do (lit) 'I consider it.'
 (adapted from S&S23:7)

In brief, SCE is restricted to *true copular verbs* and prohibited with other small clause-selecting verbs like *considerar*. Crucially, S&S23' generalization holds consistently across *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* contexts. This symmetry raises the question as to whether it extends to other ellipsis domains, such as VPE, which is addressed in the next subsection

3.2. VP ellipsis

Ellipsis of the verb phrase (VPE) in Spanish is allowed with a limit set of auxiliaries, including the progressive auxiliary *estar* and the passive auxiliary *ser*. As far I can tell, the ability of the progressive auxiliary to license VPE in the *lo-omission* context was first documented in S&S23, as exemplified below.

- (35) *lo-omission*
 a. Todos dicen que Juan está estudiando, pero no ESTÁ.
 Everyone say.3PL that Juan is.3SG studying but not is.3SG
 'Everyone says Juan is studying, but he isn't.'
 b. ?Sonia no está cantando pero Bruno sí ESTÁ.
 Sonia not is singing but Bruno yes is
 'Sonia is not singing and Bruno is, indeed'
 (S&S23:29)

Crucially, *lo-insertion* is equally grammatical with the progressive auxiliary (36), an important fact that has been overlooked in prior literature.

- (36) *lo-insertion*
 [Context: Juan's brother adores Juan. He generally copycats everything Juan does]
 Si Juan no está estudiando, tampoco lo está su hermano
 If Juan not is studying neither N.CL is his brother
 'If Juan is not studying, his brother isn't either.'

This symmetry also holds for VPE with the passive auxiliary *ser*. For speakers who accepts *lo-insertion* to occur with this auxiliary (37a), the corresponding *lo-omission* structures are likewise well-formed (37b).⁸

(37) a. *lo-insertion*

Juan fue interrogado por la policía y yo también lo fui.
 Juan was questioned by the police and I also N.CL was
 ‘Juan was questioned by the police and I was, too.’

b. *lo-omission*

Todos creen que no fui torturado, pero sí FUI.
 everyone believes that not was.1SG tortured but yes was
 ‘Everyone believes that I wasn’t tortured, but I was.’

So far, we have seen that VPE is consistently licensed in both the *lo-insertion* and the *lo-omission* context by the same class of auxiliaries. But how do auxiliaries that do not allow VPE perform in these contexts, particularly those like the perfective auxiliary *haber*? Is VPE uniformly rejected across both contexts?

The inability of the Spanish perfective auxiliary *haber* to occur with VPE has been widely documented in the literature (Martins 1994, López 1999 and much related work since). This restriction persists in the *lo-omission* context, as shown in (38a), where polarity focus is insufficient to license the ellipsis of the VP. More importantly, the same restriction extends to the *lo-insertion* context, as exemplified in (38b), where this auxiliary fails to license VPE in combination with the neuter clitic *lo*.

(38) a. *lo-omission*

*Creen que habéis llegado ya, pero no HABÉIS.
 believe.3PL that have.2PL arrived already but not have.2PL
 ‘They believe you have already arrived, but you haven’t.’

⁸ For some speakers, there seems to be a symmetrical (in this case, negative) connection between *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* with the passive auxiliary *ser*. Specifically, speakers that do not permit VPE with the passive auxiliary in the *lo-insertion* context also reject VPE with this same auxiliary in the *lo-omission* context. For instance, S&S23 consistently report *lo-insertion* sentences like (37a) to be just as ungrammatical as their *lo-omission* counterparts like (37b). However, this claim is contested by the judgments provided by other speakers—including myself—who find (37a) and (37b) equally grammatical. This (possibly idiolectal) variation (see fn. 2) lends further support for the close relationship between *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* in Spanish, as it suggests that these two constructions are either consistently permissible or uniformly prohibited for the same predicate ellipsis process (in this case, VPE).

b. *lo-insertion*

*Juan ha llegado ya y vosotros también lo habéis.
Juan has.3SG arrived already and you too N.CL have.2PL
'Juan has already arrived, and so you have'

This paradigm lends further support for treating *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* as two manifestations of the same ellipsis process (in this case, VPE). Specifically, the perfective auxiliary *haber* cannot license VPE in the *lo-omission* context (38a), nor can it do so in the *lo-insertion* context (38b). Thus, the generalization emerging from the full range of predicate ellipsis paradigms discussed in this section is that *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* are either consistently permissible or uniformly prohibited in Spanish.

(39) *lo-insertion* ↔ *lo-omission*

The auxiliaries that license predicate ellipsis in the *lo-omission* context are precisely those that license it in the *lo-insertion* context, and vice versa.

Once established the uniform licensing conditions for SCE and VPE⁹ in the *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* contexts, we next explore how S&S23' [E]-feature analysis of *lo-omission* may be extended to account for the *lo-omission/lo-insertion* alternation in Spanish.

3.3 Same ellipsis, same [E]

As said in section 1, the *lo-omission* vs. *lo-insertion* split among predicate anaphora in Spanish has not received much attention in prior literature. The notable exception is S&S23, who were the first to document and analyze the *lo-omission* construction. According to S&S23, predicate ellipsis in the *lo-omission* context is associated with the presence of a specific [E]-feature on *v*, which instructs the PF component to leave *v*'s complement unpronounced (Merchant 2001). This [E]-feature (henceforth *E_{PRED}*) is further equipped with *inflectional*, *categorial* and *selectional* features (Aelbrecht 2010), specifying the syntactic environments where *E_{PRED}* is permitted.

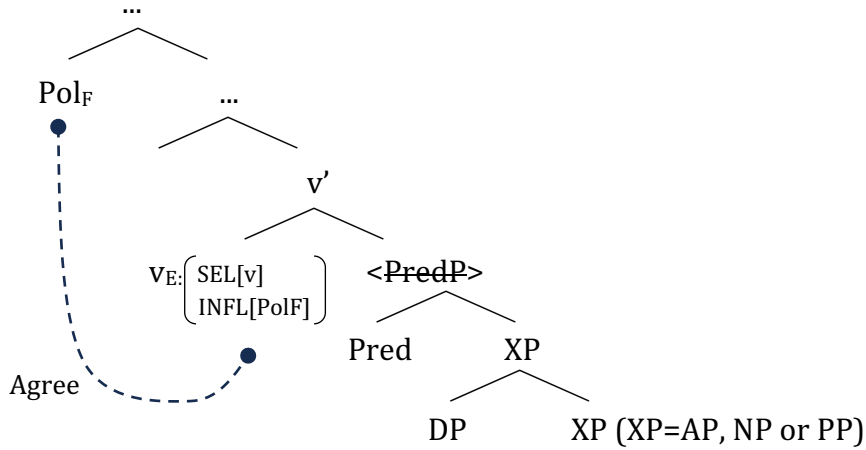
⁹ A comparison of Spanish VPE with its most studied counterpart in English reveals a significant difference in the range of licensors available for VPE. In English, this includes modals, auxiliaries, the infinitival marker *to* (Zagona 1982, 1988; Lobeck 1987) and negation (Postdam 1997), whereas in Spanish, it is restricted to the auxiliaries *ser* and *estar*. This well-documented contrast between "rich VPE" languages like English or Portuguese and "poor VPE" languages, such as Spanish and French (Authier 2023), raises a number of intriguing issues regarding the factors driving the crosslinguistic variation in the availability of VPE licensors (Martins 1994; López 1999; Cyrino and Matos 2002; Rouveret 2012; S&S23, and references therein). Unfortunately, these questions lie outside the scope of this paper and must be reserved for further research.

(40) The syntax of E_{PRED} (*lo-omission*)

$$E_{\text{PRED}} \left(\begin{array}{l} \text{CAT [E]} \\ \text{INFL [*PolF*]} \\ \text{SEL [v]} \end{array} \right) \quad (\text{adapted from S\&S23:20})$$

In copular sentences, E_{PRED} satisfies its *selectional* features (i.e., $\text{SEL}[v]$) by being attached to the [+stative], [-agentive] head hosting the copular verb: namely, v_{be} . This head selects a *PredP* containing the small clause formed by the non-verbal predicate (typically AP, NP or PP) and the subject DP (Bowers 1993, Baker 2003, Authier 2023). This configuration is schematically represented in (41), omitting details unrelated to the E_{PRED} -licensing mechanism.¹⁰

(41) Small Clause Ellipsis (*lo-omission*) (S\&S23)

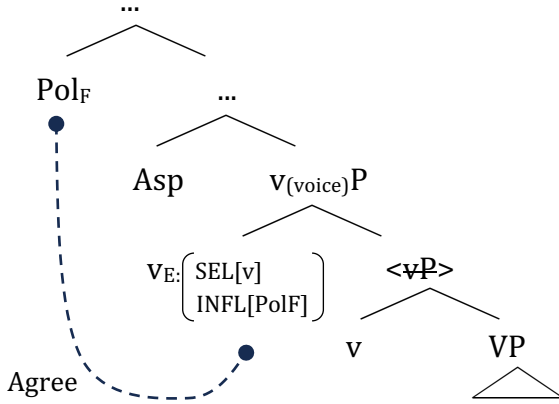


With regard to its inflectional requirements, E_{PRED} checks its uninterpretable $u\text{Pol}_F$ feature by entering into a long-distance Agree relation with a F(ocus)-marked $\text{Pol}(\text{arity})$ head higher in the structure. Consequently, E_{PRED} is only licensed under polarity focus.

Although S\&S23 do not explicitly extend their analysis to VPE in the *lo-omission* context, this extension can be straightforwardly implemented by assuming that VPE involves the presence of E_{PRED} on different “flavors” of v , such as Kratzer’s (1996) *voice* or Folly and Harley’ (2004) $v_{\text{DO}}/v_{\text{CAUSE}}$, as schematically represented below.

¹⁰ The head hosting polarity *Pol* (also referred to as Σ in the literature) has been argued to occupy a position either below T (López 1999) or above T (Laka 1990, Saab 2009). However, since the relative position of *Pol* (or Σ) with respect to T does not affect the analysis of the *lo-insertion* vs. *lo-omission* split in Spanish, this distinction will not be further explored in this paper.

(42) VP Ellipsis (*lo-omission*)



To account for the distribution of the progressive and the passive auxiliary in VPE, it is necessary to articulate specific assumptions regarding the morphological realization of $v(\text{voice})P$ in (42) and its relationship with the Asp head above it. Concretely, I assume that when $v(\text{voice})$ bears the feature [-active], this head is overtly realized as the passive auxiliary itself.

(43) VPE with the passive auxiliary *ser* (*lo-omission*)

[PolP Pol_F [TP T [$v(\text{voice})P$ < $v[-\text{active}]/[E]$, /ser/ > vP]]]

Conversely, when $v(\text{voice})$ is [+active], it behaves as a null affix, incorporating under adjacency into an overtly expressed category to satisfy well-formed conditions in Morphology, such as Lasnik's (1995) Null Affix Constraint. In such cases, the presence *Asp_{Prog}* (Cinque 2004) above $v(\text{voice})$ [+active] provides it with an appropriate host:

(44) VPE with the progressive auxiliary *estar* (*lo-omission*)

[TP T [Asp_{Prog}P Asp_{Prog}<está> [$v(\text{voice})P$ < v [+act]/[E], $\emptyset$ > vP]]]

By extending S&S23' [E_{PRED}] to different “flavors” of v , we can account for the syntactic distribution of both SCE and VPE¹¹ in the context of *lo-omission*. However, can an

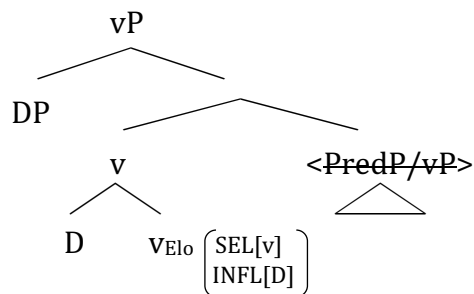
¹¹ This analysis raises, however, an important question: why is the perfective auxiliary *haber*, unlike the progressive auxiliary in *Asp_{Prog}*, unable to lend morphological support for the null affix $v(\text{voice})$? Several potential explanations could account for why the progressive auxiliary licenses VPE, while the perfective auxiliary does not (Lobeck 1995, Martins 1994, López 1999, Rouveret 2012, Saab 2022 and references therein). One hypothesis (to be further developed in future research) is based on the analysis of the perfective auxiliary as the morphological exponent of a [+perfective] feature in T, rather than a “true” auxiliary inserted into *Asp_{Perf}* (see Saab 2022 for a related proposal). According to this view, the syntactic structure underlying VPE with a perfective auxiliary would be as in (1).

(i) [TP <han>T_{[uperf], [-past], 3PL} [Asp_{Perf}P $\emptyset$ _[perf] [$v(\text{voice})P$ < v [+act]/[E], $\emptyset$ > vP]]]

analysis along these lines be extended to *lo-insertion* contexts? Such an extension would need to explain not only the syntactic distribution of *lo-insertion* but also its systematic connection with *lo-omission*.

A straightforward implementation of S&S23' [E]-feature analysis of *lo-omission* to *lo-insertion* is to propose the existence of an additional [E]-feature (call it E_{lo}).

(45)



$[E_{lo}]$ in (45) minimally differs from S&S23's $[E_{PRED}]$ in (40) in its INFL(ectio)nal feature. Specifically, the INFL[D] feature in $[E_{lo}]$ reflects the syntactic requirement that the $[E_{lo}]$ -bearing head (i.e., v) must be merged with a D-clitic—in this case, the Spanish neuter clitic *lo*.

By assigning *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* their own [E]-feature (i.e., E_{PRED} and E_{lo}), this analysis successfully describes the syntactic licensing pattern of each construction. However, treating *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* as two independent ellipsis constructions misses a crucial generalization: both constructions are licensed by the same close-knit class of auxiliaries. Additionally, describing *lo-omission* as occurring under polarity focus and *lo-insertion* as co-occurring with a neuter pronominal clitic fails to explain the semantic contribution of polarity focus or the clitic *lo* to the interpretative mechanisms associated with ellipsis. As a consequence of this, under to this analysis, it is not possible to account for why *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* differ only in their use on polarity focus versus a clitic, while all other properties remain consistent across both constructions.

To address these issues, I propose reducing the syntactic licensing patterns exhibited by these two predicate ellipsis constructions to a single [E]-feature:

Assuming that Asp_{Perf} in (i) must be syntactically projected (possibly for checking the uninterpretable $[uperf]$ feature in T), the null affixal Asp_{Perf} intervenes between $v(voice)$ and T, preventing the affixal $v(voice)$ from incorporating into T. As a result, $v(voice)$ in (i) remains stranded, unable to incorporate into a suitable host. This violates the Null Affix Constraint, thereby excluding this structure.

- (46) The syntax of the *lo-omission/lo-insertion* alternation
 E[**uv*]

Following Merchant (2001), this [E]-feature includes selectional features specifying the head it merges with during derivation. Specifically, [E] carries an uninterpretable, strong **uv* feature, which must enter into a local head-head checking relation with (various “flavors” of) v.

This unified analysis straightforwardly accounts for the symmetrical licensing of *lo-omission* and *lo-insertion* by the same set of auxiliaries (both in SCE and VPE). However, it does not yet explain the syntactic divergences between these two constructions: *lo-omission* being licensed under polarity focus, and *lo-insertion* requiring the presence of the neuter clitic *lo*. In the next section, I explore the hypothesis that polarity focus and the neuter clitic *lo* are two alternative strategies to satisfy the semantic requirements of [E] and consequently [E]’s syntax needs not to encode them.

4. Same [E], different pronominal variables

In this section, I argue that the presence of the clitic *lo* (in *lo-insertion*) and its absence under polarity focus (in *lo-omission*) represent two alternative strategies to satisfy the semantic requirements of the [E]-feature that licenses predicate ellipsis in Spanish. Section 4.1 illustrates how Merchant’s (2001) Focus Condition on ellipsis works, with an emphasis on the key role that the concept of *e-GIVENness* plays in ellipsis licensing. In Section 4.2, I propose encoding *e-GIVENness* into the semantics of [E] as a binary relation, rather than a monadic predicate as in Merchant (2001). Building on this proposal, I show how the *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* alternants of predicate ellipsis can be derived directly from the semantics of a single [E], eliminating the need to posit two distinct [E]-features. Finally, I briefly explore similar predicate ellipsis constructions in Germanic languages, which employ strategies for predicate anaphora akin to both *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission*, albeit with a different distribution

4.1 Focus Condition on Ellipsis.

A central condition on ellipsis is that the content of the elided material must be recoverable from a syntactically matching antecedent within the discourse (Hankamer and Sag 1976, Chomsky and Lasnik 1993, Merchant 2001, Aelbrecht 2010 and references therein). According to Merchant (2001), the identity requirement between the ellipsis site and its antecedent is governed by the Focus condition in (47).

- (47) **Focus Condition** (Merchant 2001:26)
 A constituent α can be elided if α is e-GIVEN.

This condition builds on the concept of e-GIVENness, defined as in (48).

- (48) e-GIVENness (Merchant 2001:31)
An expression E counts as a e-GIVEN iff E has a salient antecedent A and, modulo $\exists$ -type shifting,
(i) A entails F-clo (E), and
(ii) E entails F-clo(A).

In Merchant (2001:14), F-closure, written as F-clo, is defined as follows:

- (49) **F-closure**
F-clo of α is the result of replacing F(ocus)-marked parts of α with $\exists$ -bound variables of the appropriate type (modulo $\exists$ -type shifting)

To illustrate how e-GIVENness works, consider (50a), where the elided VP (VPE) is semantically interpreted as (50b).

- (50) a. Abby ate a sandwich after BEN did. (Merchant 2001: (45b))
b. ... after BEN did [_{VPE} ~~eat a sandwich~~]

The VP antecedent of (50b) (i.e., VPA) corresponds to [_{VPA} *t_{Abby} ate a sandwich*] in the main clause. Because VPA contains the trace of the subject DP *Abby*, $\exists$ -type shifting applies to it, yielding (51) (the single quotation mark is used to indicate $\exists$ -type shifting).

- (51) VPA' = $\exists x$. x ate a sandwich

The first part of (48) establishes that (51) must entail F-clo (VPE). Applying F-closure to the VPE in (50b) involves replacing the F-marked trace of the subject with an existentially bound variable, resulting in (52).

- (52) F-clo(VPE) = $\exists x$. x ate a sandwich

Since (51) entails (52), the elided VP in (50b) satisfy the first part of (48). However, for this VP to be e-GIVEN, F-clo(VPA), shown in (53a), must also entail VPE' in (53b).

- (53) a. F-clo(VPA) = $\exists x$. x ate a sandwich
b. VPE' = $\exists x$. x ate a sandwich

As F-clo (VPA) in (53a) and VPE' in (53b) are identical, this latter VP satisfies e-GIVENness and can be elided. The Focus Condition in (47) thus ensures ellipsis is licensed based on a semantic equivalence (i.e., e-GIVENness) between the ellipsis site and its antecedent. However, it is important to note the ongoing debate about whether this equivalence is primarily semantic (Merchant 2001), syntactic (Lasnik 1995; Fiengo and May 1994; Chung 2013) or a combination of both (Merchant 2008a). Each approach has to deal with distinct empirical challenges and the debate remains open to date.

4.2 Deriving the Spanish Predicate Ellipsis Alternation from Dyadic $\llbracket E \rrbracket$

Following Merchant (2001), I assume that $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ encodes the Focus condition as a presupposition (i.e., that the EC is e-GIVEN). However, I depart from Merchant (2001) in formalizing the e-GIVEN notion as a binary predicate.

$$(54) \quad \llbracket E \rrbracket = \lambda p_1 \lambda p_2: e - GIVEN(p_1, p_2). p_1$$

This entry is truth-conditionally equivalent to that originally proposed by Merchant (2001) for $\llbracket E \rrbracket$, given in (55):

$$(55) \quad \llbracket E \rrbracket = \lambda p: e - GIVEN(p). p \quad (\text{Merchant 2001})$$

Both entries in (54) and (55) impose the same condition on the elided constituent: it must be e-GIVEN. However, the semantics of $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ in (54) establishes a more direct mapping between the e-GIVEN relation (i.e., EC and AC entail each other) and the LF-structure where this relation holds.

(56) a.

b. $\llbracket H_E \rrbracket(\llbracket pro_{ANT} \rrbracket)(\llbracket XP \rrbracket) = \llbracket XP \rrbracket$ iff e-GIVEN($\llbracket pro_{ANT} \rrbracket$, $\llbracket XP \rrbracket$); undefined, otherwise

In order to be well-formed, $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ in (56) must take two distinct arguments: (ii) a pronominal variable anaphorically linked to the AC, and (ii) the EC itself. As a result, the E-bearing head, H_E , must adjoin to a pronominal variable anaphoric to the AC; otherwise, the semantic value of $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ would be left undefined.

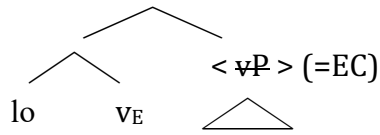
Building on this analysis, it is possible to derive the *lo-insertion* vs. *lo-omission* split in Spanish from a single $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ -feature:

(57) The syntax of the *lo-omission/lo-insertion* alternation (Spanish)
 $E[*uv]$

In *lo-insertion*, the clitic *lo* is anaphorically associated with the AC. Upon merging with the E-bearing head, *lo* serves as a one of the semantic arguments of $\llbracket E \rrbracket$, with the other argument being the EC itself, as schematically represented in Figure 1. Hence, for predicate ellipsis to be licensed in the *lo-insertion* context, the clitic *lo* must be anaphoric to an antecedent constituent that stands in a e-GIVEN relation with the ellipsis site.

Figure 1. *lo-insertion*

LF:

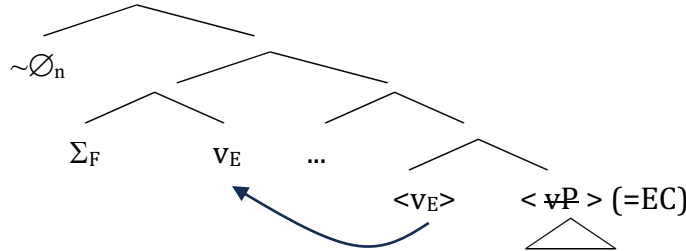


SEM: $\llbracket H_E \rrbracket(\llbracket lo_{ANT} \rrbracket)(\llbracket vP \rrbracket) = \llbracket vP \rrbracket$ iff e-GIVEN($\llbracket lo_{ANT} \rrbracket$, $\llbracket vP \rrbracket$); undefined, otherwise

In contrast, in *lo-omission*, that very same licensing head (i.e., v_E) moves to adjoin to a F(ocus)-marking category (typically, Σ_F), as roughly represented in Figure 2. In this configuration, the argument of $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ associated with the AC is supplied by a silent contextual variable: namely, $\emptyset_n$.

Figure 2. *lo-omission*

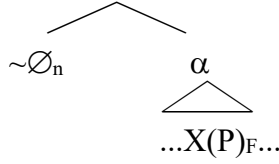
LF:



SEM: $\llbracket H_E \rrbracket(\llbracket \emptyset_{ANT} \rrbracket)(\llbracket vP \rrbracket) = \llbracket vP \rrbracket$ iff e-GIVEN($\llbracket \emptyset_{ANT} \rrbracket$, $\llbracket vP \rrbracket$); undefined, otherwise

The contextual variable, $\emptyset_n$, in Figure 2 is introduced as an argument of Rooth's (1992) squiggle operator ($\sim$), which in turns attaches to a syntactic constituent α dominating a F(ocus)-marked category. This focus configuration is felicitous only if the contextual variable $\emptyset_n$ holds one of two specific relations with the focus value of α (Rooth 1992:93).

(58)



presupposes that either...

- a. *INDIVIDUAL CASE*: The contextually supplied value of C_n is identical to an element of the focus value semantic value of α (formally, $\llbracket C_n \rrbracket^0 \in \llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f$)
- b. *SET CASE*: The contextually supplied value of C_n is identical to, or a subset of, the focus value semantic value of α (formally, $\llbracket C_n \rrbracket^0 \subseteq \llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f$)
- (adapted from Büring 2016:37)

This analysis of *lo-omission* assumes that the contextual variable, i.e., $\emptyset$, is anaphorically linked to the constituent serving as the antecedent of the ellipsis site. However, this assumption is incorrect in most cases. For instance, as shown by the LF-structure corresponding to the *lo-omission* example in (59), the contextual variable $\emptyset_1$ in the second conjunct is anaphoric to $[\Sigma_{PA} \text{ no es } [\text{PredP } \text{feliz}]]$. Yet, the ellipsis site in the LF in (60), i.e., ~~feliz~~, is a sub-part of Σ_{PA} . In fact, the constituent that satisfies e-GIVENness in (60) for the semantics of $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ is not the ellipsis site itself, but the sister to the squiggle operator $\sim \emptyset_1$ in the second conjunct: namely, $\Sigma_F P$.¹²

- (59) Sonia no es feliz, pero Bruno sí ES.
 Sonia not is happy but Bruno yes is
 ‘Sonia is not happy, but Bruno is indeed.’

- (60) Sonia $[\Sigma_{PA} \text{ no es feliz}]_1$ pero Bruno $[\sim \emptyset_1 [\Sigma_{FP} \text{ sí}_F \text{ ES}_E \text{ ~~feliz~~}]$

There are several options to account for this mismatch between the e-GIVEN constituent and the ellipsis site in (60). One option is to make the Focus condition in (47) more flexible, as shown in (61), where a constituent is considered e-GIVEN if it is contained in a constituent that is in turn e-GIVEN.

¹² The focus value of $\llbracket [\Sigma_F P \text{ sí}_F \text{ es } \text{feliz}] \rrbracket^f$ in (60) is, roughly speaking, the set obtained by substituting F-marked elements with alternatives of the same semantic type: i.e., $\{\text{sí es feliz, no es feliz}\}$. Consequently, since $\llbracket [\Sigma_{PA} \text{ no es feliz}] \rrbracket^0 \in \llbracket [\Sigma_F P \text{ sí}_F \text{ es } \text{feliz}] \rrbracket^f$, this LF-structure satisfies Rooth’s (1992) individual case in (58b). It also fulfils the first part of the e-GIVENness condition (see Merchant 2001; Gengel 2013 for the equivalence of Rooth’s (1992) semantics of *givenness* and Schwarzschild’s (1999) notion of entailment-based *givenness*, the formalism Merchant (2001) adopts in defining e-GIVENness.). Assuming that the negative particle *no* contained in Σ_{PA} in (60) is F-marked (as it contrasts with the positive particle *sí* ‘yes’ in the second conjunct), it follows that $\llbracket [\Sigma_F P \text{ sí}_F \text{ es } \text{feliz}] \rrbracket^0 \in \llbracket [\Sigma_{PA} \text{ no}_F \text{ es } \text{feliz}] \rrbracket^f$. This satisfies the second part of the e-GIVENness condition.

(61) **Focus Condition (Version I)**

A constituent α can be elided if

i. α is e-GIVEN, or

ii. α is reflexively dominated by β and β is e-GIVEN.

Another option is to assume that it is the maximal projection of the [E]-bearing head, rather than its sister, the constituent that must be e-GIVEN.

(62) **Focus Condition (Version II)**

A constituent α can be elided if the maximal projection of α 's sister is e-GIVEN

Either option can explain the mismatch seen in *lo-omission* structure like (60) between the e-GIVEN constituent and the ellipsis site. However, deciding between these two options is beyond the scope of this paper, and I leave this issue¹³ for further research.

What is of interest to us here is that the contextual variable $\emptyset_n$ associated with focus in Figure 2 serves a dual role: (i) as the background argument for focus and (ii) as the argument of $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ that is anaphorically linked to the Antecedent Constituent.

This analysis allows us to derive *lo-insertion* and *lo-omission* as two contextual variants for predicate ellipsis in Spanish. This is so because both constructions feature the same [E]-bearing head in two distinct licensing configurations. More specifically, in the *lo-insertion* context (63a), the clitic *lo* supplies $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ with a semantic argument linked to the AC, while in *lo-omission* (63b), this very same argument is provided instead by the contextual variable associated with focus. Furthermore, this analysis correctly excludes (63c); here, neither the clitic *lo* nor polarity focus provide $\llbracket E \rrbracket$ with an argument associated with the AC. Consequently, the semantic value of the E-feature underlying (63) remains undefined, preventing the lexical predicate to undergo deletion.

(63) a. *lo-insertion*

María es una buena profesora y Cristina también lo es.

María is a good teacher and Cristina also CL.N is

‘María is a good teacher, and Cristina is, too.’

¹³ In his (2019) investigation of the constraints on A'-extraction out of VPE —known as *MaxElide* since Merchant (2008b)—, Griffiths argues that “for a phrase containing an ellipsis site to satisfy the recoverability condition on ellipsis [i.e., e-GIVENness], it must have a focus semantic value” [Griffiths 2019: 3]. Accordingly, it is unsurprising that the constituent satisfying e-GIVENness in *lo-omission* structures like (60) contains both a F-marked category (i.e., Σ_F) and the ellipsis site.

b. lo-omission

Sonia no es feliz pero Bruno sí ES.
Sonia not is happy but Bruno yes is
'Sonia is not happy, but Bruno is indeed.'

c. neither lo-omission nor lo-insertion

*María es una buena profesora y Cristina también es.
María is a good teacher and Cristina also is
'Maria is a good teacher, and Cristina is, too.'

This analysis can be extended to account for the crosslinguistic variation found among different predicate ellipsis constructions. For instance, López and Winkler (2000) argue that VPE in English requires the auxiliary to carry a pitch accent associated with a Polarity Focus feature. This is evidenced by the fact that reduced or contracted auxiliaries result in ungrammaticality in the context of VPE.

(64) VP ellipsis (English)

John said that he has read Dostoyevsky's *Idiot*, but he {HASN'T/ *hasn't}.
[hæznt]/*[hæznt]

(slightly modified from López and Winkle (2000: (33a))

Thus, If López and Winkler (2000) analysis of English VPE is on the right track, then English would employ a focus strategy similar to that found in Spanish *lo-omission* to license predicate ellipsis. However, it is well-known that English cannot use a neuter pronoun in combination with an auxiliary to form a predicate anaphora. In other words, a strategy comparable to Spanish *lo-insertion* is not available for VPE in English.

(65) a. *John was arrested and Peter was {it/that} too.

b. *John is enthusiastic and Jan is {it/that} too.

However, among Germanic languages, English appears to be the exception rather than the rule. North Germanic languages like Norwegian, Danish and Swedish make productive use of the neuter demonstrative *det* 'that' as a VP anaphor in combination with an auxiliary, as exemplified in (66) for Norwegian.

(66) a. Kari ble arrestert, men Jan ble ikke det. (Norwegian)

Kari became arrested but Jan became not it
'Kari was arrested, but Jan wasn't'

b. Kari er begeistret og Jan er også det. (Norwegian)

Kari is enthusiastic and Jan is also it
'Kari is enthusiastic and Jan is too.'

(Bentzen et al. 2013: (6b)-(6c))

Although the VP-pronominalization structures like (66) in Norwegian differ from English VPE in leaving a neuter demonstrative as an anaphoric VP, they behave like VPE in the standard tests diagnosing ellipsis (see Bentzen, Merchant and Svenonius 2013 for Norwegian; Houser, Mikkelsen and Toosarvandani 2006 for Danish; Vinka and Waldmann 2014 for Swedish). Therefore, Scandinavian languages use a pronominalization strategy analogous to Spanish *lo-insertion*, which is not available in other Germanic languages like English—for reasons that are yet poorly understood.

The crosslinguistic variation observed in predicate ellipsis constructions raises several important issues that warrant further investigation, particularly regarding why strategies like overt predicate proforms or polarity focus vary across languages. A potentially fruitful hypothesis, to be developed in future work, is to posit that *lo-insertion*-like strategies arise as a last resort. Specifically, when the licensing head is not able to raise to a higher F-marked head, the presence of an overt proform (e.g., the Spanish neuter clitic *lo* or the Scandinavian neuter demonstrative *det*) closes $[[E]]$ by providing it with an argument anaphoric to the AC. If this hypothesis proves correct, the crosslinguistic variation between the overt proform and (polarity) focus strategies in the domain of predicate anaphora might be attributed to the licensing head's (in)ability to raise via head-movement to a F-marked category.

5. Conclusions

This paper has presented a novel analysis of the *lo-insertion* vs. *lo-omission* split in Spanish, offering a unified explanation for the syntactic and semantic distribution of these two predicate ellipsis constructions. By unifying these constructions under a single $[E]$ -feature and treating their divergences as alternative strategies to satisfy $[E]$'s semantic requirements, this analysis resolves the challenges that this alternation poses for Merchant's theory of ellipsis licensing. This unified approach not only simplifies the syntactic characterization of predicate ellipsis in Spanish but also contributes to the study of the crosslinguistic variation in predicate ellipsis constructions more broadly.

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